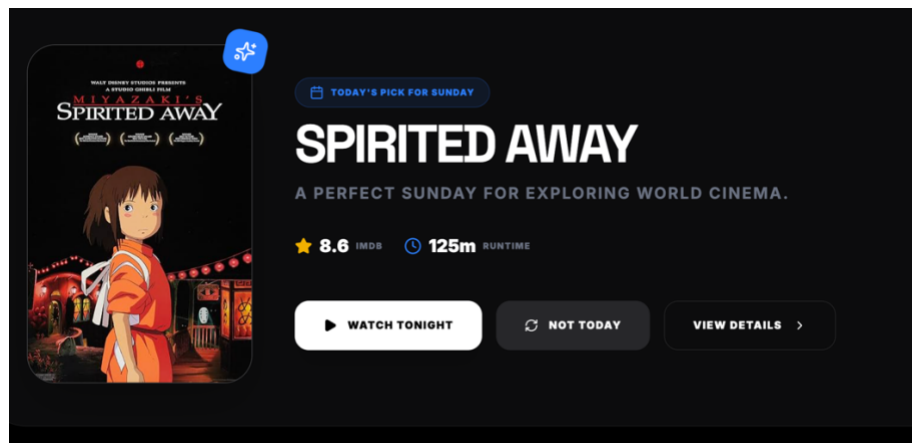


PRODUCT CASE STUDY

CineTrack

Your Cinema, Your Rules.

CineTrack is a cinematic journaling system designed to make movie-watching feel reflective, immersive, and worth returning to.



Author / PM	Arunjyoti Kalita
Role	Aspiring Product Manager & Builder
Timeline	3–4 weeks (alongside other projects)
Live URL	aura-cinetrack.vercel.app
Stack	React 19 • TypeScript • Firebase • D3.js • Recharts • Framer Motion
Type	Personal Project — Case Study

00 Why I Built CineTrack

I have loved cinema for as long as I can remember. But I could never find a tool that matched how I experienced films — as something personal, worth reflecting on, and geographically wide-ranging. Letterboxd felt like a social feed. IMDb felt like a database. Notion felt like a spreadsheet. None of them made the act of logging feel meaningful or helped me understand how my taste was evolving. CineTrack started as a personal tool to fix that frustration — and became a product design exercise in building for a specific kind of user: someone who watches films thoughtfully and wants that reflected to them.

01 The TL;DR

CineTrack is a personal cinematic journal and analytics dashboard built for movie enthusiasts who want more than just a watchlist. It combines immersive UI design, deep metadata tracking, geographical cinema analytics, and lightweight progression systems — all in one place.

10+ Core Features Built	30+ Metadata Fields	190+ Countries Mapped	3–4w Build Timeline
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02 The Problem

The Fragmented Cinephile

Letterboxd	Social-first. Great for sharing opinions, weak on personal analytics, data depth, and immersion.
IMDb	A database, not a journal. No personalisation, no emotional layer, no taste tracking.
Notion templates	Flexible but entirely manual. No visualisation, no cinematic feel, very high setup friction.

Core User Pain Points

- Log fatigue — opening a full form just to record a movie felt like homework
- Surface-level insights — "you watched 47 movies" is not a useful insight for someone who cares about cinema
- No emotional layer — nowhere to capture how a film made you feel
- No geographical awareness — users had no idea how narrow their cinematic world was
- No reason to return — no streaks, no milestones, no sense of progress

"What if there was an app that treated your movie history the way Spotify Wrapped treats your music — making it feel personal, visual, and worth sharing?"

03 Who It Was Built For

Rather than conducting formal surveys, CineTrack was built with a group of real movie enthusiasts who used it from day one — giving the product something most early tools lack: honest, continuous, real-world feedback from people who cared about the problem.

Users Were Present from the Start

- Used regularly from the beginning — not as a favour, but because the problem was real for them too
- Genuine friction points and bugs were reported as they appeared in real sessions
- Feature requests came from actual frustration — the Arena challenge came from users wanting a competitive element
- Usage patterns were observable firsthand: what got logged, what got skipped, what got talked about

Two User Personas

The Pro-Cinephile	Film students, critics, and dedicated enthusiasts watching 100+ titles/year. Cares deeply about directors, global cinema, and insight — not just a list.
The List-Maker	Users motivated by completion, milestones, and collecting. Driven by progress and the satisfaction of a full shelf.
Shared Core Need	Both want a product that respects their taste, reflects it back meaningfully, and makes logging feel worthwhile rather than tedious.

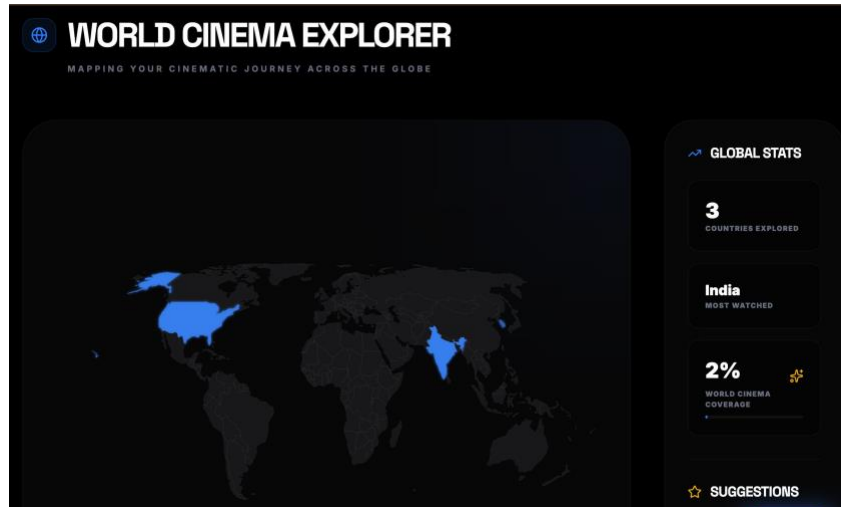
04 The Key Insight — The Cinematic Passport

The feature that ultimately shaped the product most — the World Cinema Map — came not from a planning session, but from a personal moment.

I was at an airport, passport in hand, waiting for my flight. I looked at the stamps — each one a record of a country I had physically visited. And it hit me: what if CineTrack did the same thing, but for the countries I had explored through cinema?

Just as a passport marks the countries you have been to, CineTrack's World Cinema Map stamps the countries whose films you have watched. Countries light up as you log films from them. Click on any country and see every title you have watched from there — the year, the genre, your personal rating.

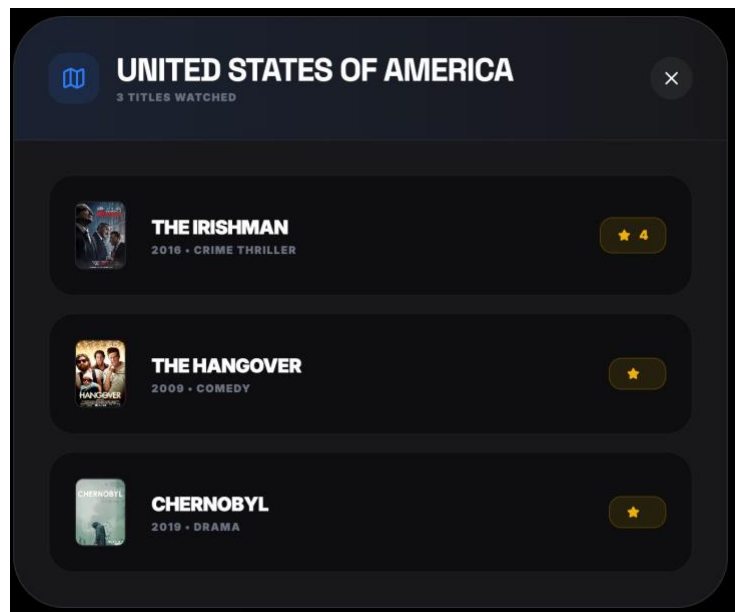
A sidebar shows Global Stats: countries explored, most-watched country, and percentage of world cinema coverage. A Suggestions panel nudges you toward unexplored territories — France, Japan, Brazil — just like a traveller planning their next destination.



World Cinema Explorer — countries light up as you log films from them

Why the Passport Metaphor Changed the Product

- Reframed what CineTrack is — not a database, but a passport for your cinematic journey
- Created a clear point of difference — no other tracker visualises viewing as geographical exploration
- Solved a problem user didn't know they had — most people are genuinely surprised by how narrow their viewing geography is
- Users became more aware of their viewing blind spots, and started seeking out films from countries they had never explored
- Built-in intrinsic motivation — filling the map feels exactly like collecting passport stamps



Country Drill-Down Modal — every title watched from that country, with rating

05 What Was Built

CineTrack was designed around three product goals: reduce logging friction, deepen reflection, and create lightweight progression that sustains long-term use. Rather than adding disconnected features, each component was built to reinforce one of those goals.

The Three Signature Experiences

These are the features that define what CineTrack is — the ones users remember, talk about, and come back for.

1. World Cinema Map

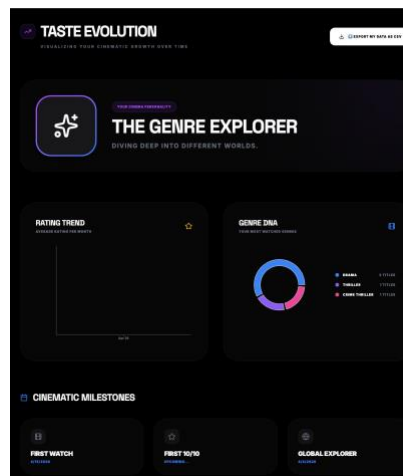
Transforms movie tracking into geographical exploration. Countries light up as films are logged. Click any country to see every title watched there — year, genre, personal rating. Global Stats sidebar shows countries explored, most-watched country, and world cinema coverage percentage. A Suggestions panel nudges users toward unexplored territories.

Outcome: users emotionally connected with the "cinematic passport" idea from first use, and began logging more intentionally to fill the map.

2. Taste Evolution & Cinema Personality

Shows how a user's cinematic taste changes over time. Assigns a derived Cinema Personality label (e.g. "The Genre Explorer") based on viewing patterns. Includes a time-series Rating Trend chart and a Genre DNA donut chart showing the distribution of most-watched genres.

Outcome: users saw a reflection of their taste they had never been shown before — making the product feel genuinely personal rather than generic.



Taste Evolution — Cinema Personality, Rating Trend, and Genre DNA

3. Quick Log FAB

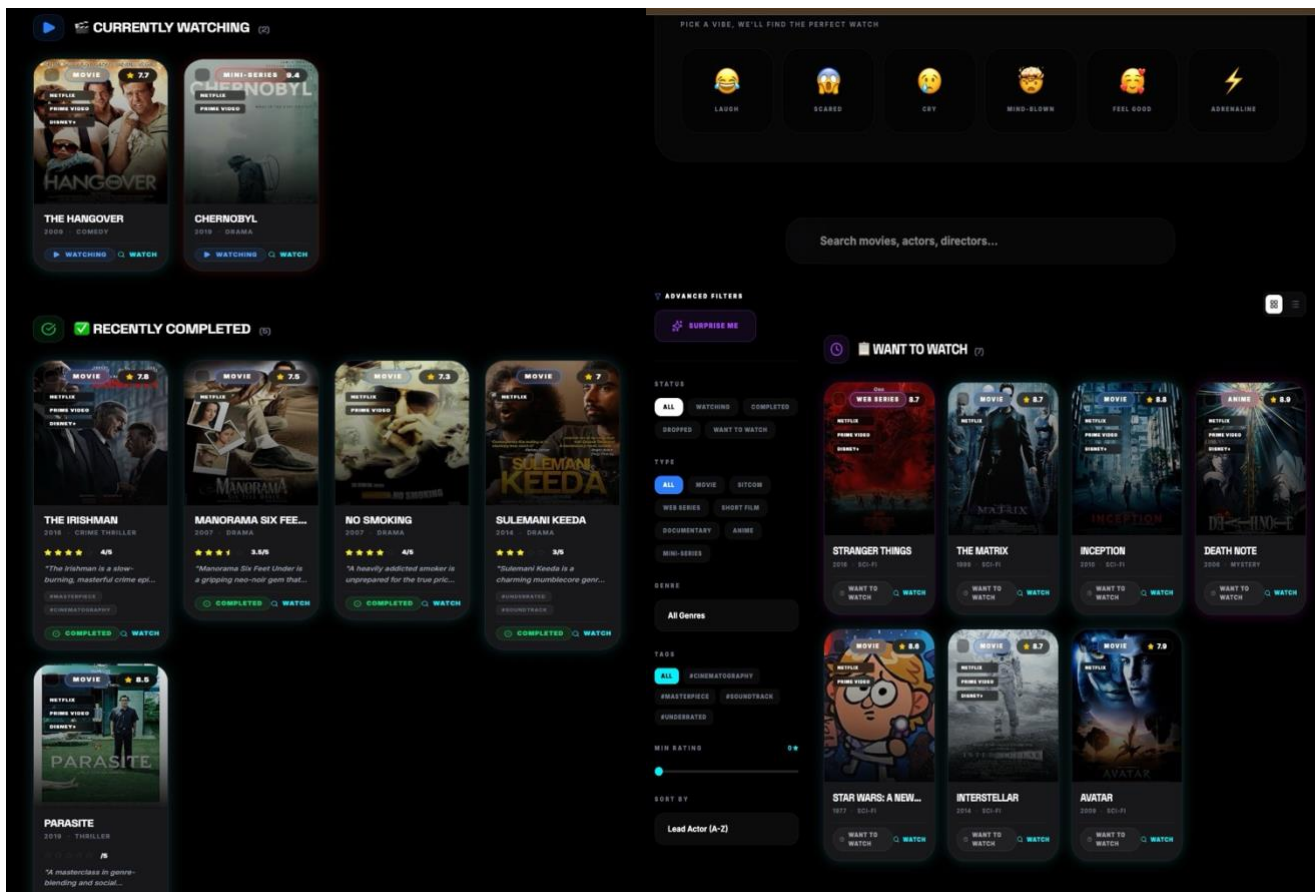
A floating action button that captures a new entry in seconds — just a title and rating. Deep journaling becomes opt-in, not required. Autocomplete is powered by a custom prefix index with fuzzy matching, so typing "Inception" still finds "Inception".

Outcome: removed the biggest barrier between finishing a film and logging it. One tap to record; unlimited time to reflect later.

Quick Log FAB — fast entry with autocomplete and fuzzy search

Foundational Utility Layer

My Cinema Diary	Rich journal entries with personal review, director, watched date, mood emoji, IMDb rating comparison, and a recommendation badge.
Mood-Based Discovery	"What's Your Mood Tonight?" — 6 emotional modes (Laugh, Scared, Cry, Mind-Blown, Feel Good, Adrenaline). Built around emotional intent rather than algorithmic output.
Advanced Filters	Status, Type (Movie/Series/Documentary/Anime/Mini-Series), Tags, Min Rating, Sort By, and a Surprise Me random pick.
Custom Lists & Watchlist	Flexible personal organisation for different kinds of collections.

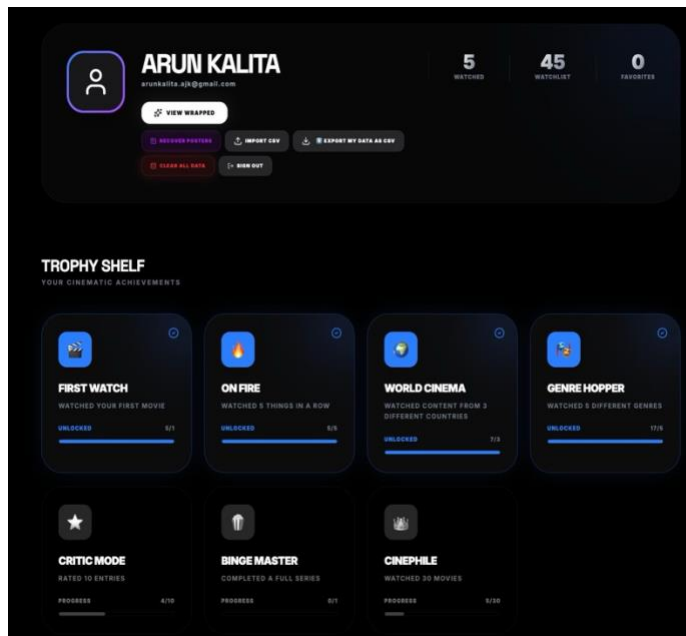


My Cinema Diary — journal entry card with review, mood, and rating. || Mood-Based Discovery and Advanced Filters

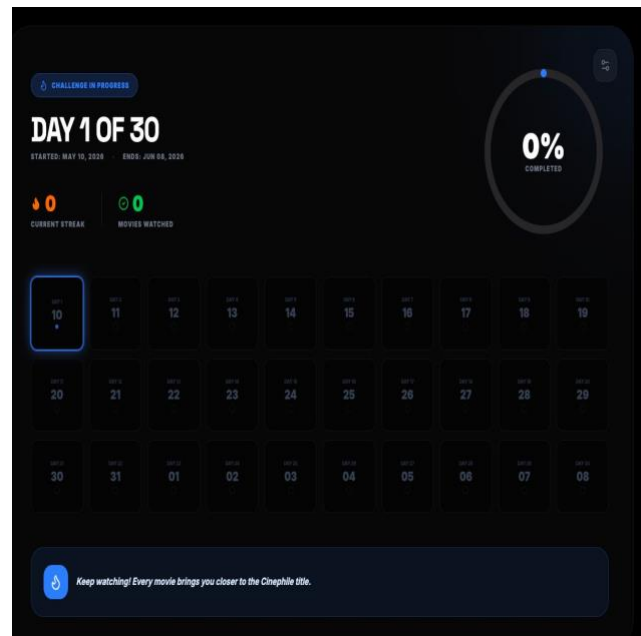
Progression & Retention Layer

Rather than relying on notifications or external pressure, CineTrack uses lightweight progression to make consistency feel intrinsically rewarding.

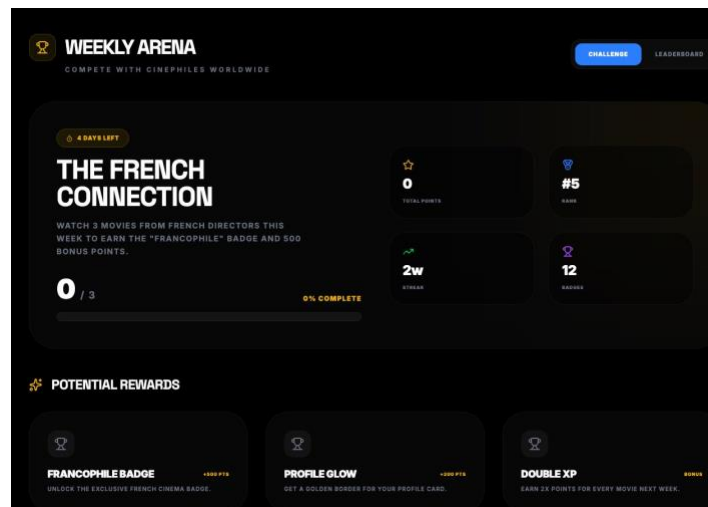
Trophy Shelf	7 achievements with progress bars — First Watch, On Fire (5 in a row), World Cinema (3 countries), Genre Hopper, Critic Mode, Binge Master, Cinephile (30 movies). Progression systems encouraged return usage without any push notifications.
30-Day Challenge	A calendar-grid sprint with daily streak tracking, a circular completion ring, and contextual motivational messages. Runs for 30 consecutive days from a chosen start date.
Weekly Arena	Competitive themed challenges (e.g. "The French Connection" — watch 3 films by French directors to earn the Francophile Badge + 500 points). Global leaderboard, streaks, and bonus rewards like Profile Glow and Double XP.



Trophy Shelf :unlocked achievements & progress on locked ones



30-Day Challenge calendar grid sprint with streak



Weekly Arena — themed challenge with points, rank, and potential rewards

06 How It Was Built

CineTrack was built through rapid AI-assisted iteration — combining conversational prototyping, live user feedback, and fast deployment cycles to evolve the product in near real time.

The Build Journey

- Started with AI-assisted vibe coding using Google AI Studio to build the initial version rapidly
- Deployed immediately to Vercel — gave users a live URL from day one

aura-cinetrack.vercel.app

- Initial storage used LocalStorage — fast to implement but quickly showed limitations around persistence and cross-device sync
- Migrated to Firebase Firestore as usage grew — a userStorage.ts bridge ensured zero data loss for all existing users
- Continued iterating in VS Code with Claude and Antigravity as real feedback came in
- Added a custom high-performance search engine (Prefix Index + Levenshtein fuzzy matching) after observing log friction in actual user sessions

AI dramatically accelerated execution, but product direction came from observing user behaviour, identifying friction, and deciding what to build next.

Key Technical Decisions

Firebase over LocalStorage	As usage became more consistent, data persistence became critical to user trust. The migration bridge ensured no user lost data.
Custom Fuzzy Search	Prefix index seeded with 150 popular titles plus the user's own library for zero-latency autocomplete. Levenshtein Distance for typo tolerance.
D3 World Map	Built with D3-geo and TopoJSON using the Equal Earth Projection — chosen for accuracy in representing relative country sizes.
Framer Motion + Tailwind v4	60FPS cinematic transitions. Tailwind v4's zero-runtime approach keeps performance tight on a data-intensive dashboard.

07 Tradeoffs That Shaped the Product

Every significant feature came from a real decision point. A recurring product principle throughout CineTrack: resist depth that increases cognitive load without strengthening the core experience.

Decision 1 — Quick Log FAB Over Form-First

- Problem: Users were skipping logging because opening the full entry form felt like too much effort after finishing a film
- Options: Simplify the main form vs. add a fast secondary entry path
- Decision: Build the Quick Log FAB — captures just title and rating instantly. Deep journaling becomes opt-in
- Outcome: Removed the biggest barrier between watching and logging. Consistency of journaling improved noticeably

Decision 2 — Mood Filter Over AI Recommendations

- Problem: "What should I watch tonight?" is the most common decision fatigue moment for movie lovers
- Options: AI recommendation engine vs. mood-based filter
- Decision: Ship the Mood filter first — faster to build, emotionally intuitive, requires no training data
- Outcome: A feature that feels deeply personal without any ML complexity. AI recommendations are on the roadmap once behavioural data matures

Decision 3 — Ship Early With Real Users

- Problem: Without a formal research process, real feedback was needed fast
- Decision: Share the live URL with movie-enthusiast friends immediately — even before the product was polished
- Outcome: Real usage patterns, genuine bug reports, and feature requests grounded in actual friction. The Arena competitive challenges came directly from users wanting a social element

Decision 4 — Migrate to Firebase

- Problem: LocalStorage worked early but broke cross-device sync and was not a stable long-term foundation
 - Decision: Accept the complexity of Firebase migration and build a proper data bridge
 - Outcome: True cloud sync, reliable persistence, zero data loss during migration
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08 Results & What I Learned

What Created Pull

- The UI quality consistently surprised users — the cinematic dark aesthetic made the product feel premium from the first session
- The World Cinema Map became the most talked-about feature — users immediately wanted to fill the map and started logging more intentionally to do it
- Quick Log FAB significantly reduced drop-off between watching and logging
- The Trophy Shelf created genuine moment-to-moment motivation — users checked their progress without being prompted
- Friends-as-beta-users delivered faster, more honest feedback than any formal research process could have

What Still Feels Unresolved

- Integrate OMDb or TMDb API autofill earlier — manual entry of director, year, country, and runtime remain the single biggest friction point for new users
- Prioritise Arena and social features sooner — competitive features drove the most re-engagement conversations
- Set up basic analytics from day one — even simple event logging would have helped understand actual usage patterns, not just perceived ones

What the Product Reinforced

- The best insights come from living the problem — the World Cinema Map came from an airport moment, not a brainstorm
 - Real users beat hypothetical personas every time — direct feedback cannot be replicated by any research document
 - Points of difference matter more than points of parity — users remember the Cinema Map; they take the Watchlist for granted
 - Ship early and iterate fast — every week of real usage made the product meaningfully better
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09 What's Next

CineTrack is live and actively used. The next phase is less about adding features and more about deepening the experiences already emerging in v1.

AI Recommendations	A "What should I watch?" button that analyses Taste Evolution + current Mood to suggest a title. The natural evolution of the Mood filter.
Director Streak	A progress bar to complete a director's full filmography — turning the Director Profile from a passive view into an active challenge.
Cinematic Wrapped Export	Auto-generated shareable PDF of the user's cinematic year — going beyond the in-app infographic modal.
Collaborative Arena	A/B testing a group-vote Weekly Poll against the current solo challenge — to understand if social coordination drives more engagement than individual competition.
Deeper Series & Anime	Episodic progress tracking — currently supported at a basic level, deserving of its own dedicated experience.

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